gain momentum from 2005–2006 onwards, the group increased its efforts to recruit and deploy fighters to Afghanistan. Over time an increasing number of its members and potential recruits also became motivated more by anti-Americanism than jihad against India.[22] This contributed to debates within the group about how involved it should become on the Afghan front.

Fighting in Afghanistan necessitated an expanded presence in the Tribal Areas and NWFP, where a proto-insurgency against Pakistan was developing. Pro-Taliban Pashtun tribesmen who ultimately coalesced to form the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan [TTP or Pakistani Taliban] were in the vanguard of attacks against the Pakistani military, working alongside al-Qaeda and a cast of actors from various Deobandi outfits. By 2007 a full-blown insurgency had erupted, heralding the advent of an unprecedented revolutionary jihad in Pakistan. Thus, Lashkar militants were increasing their presence in FATA at a time when the dominant actors in the region were pro-Taliban tribesmen aligned with the Deobandi school of thought, many of whom were at war with the state. Given Lashkar's Ahl-e-Hadith identity and close relationship with the ISI, this sometimes sparked conflict. These episodes were the exception, not the rule, and collaboration with these and other militants increased. The result was that by 2008, this was 'not your mother's LeT' to quote one Pakistan-based Western diplomat.[23] Before exploring Lashkar's operations in Afghanistan and attendant collaboration with other outfits based in FATA, let us first turn to its India-centric activities.

Pakistan's Gas Stove

Although Pakistan was clamping down on militancy, eliminating its proxy capability would rob the state of what some in the army and ISI perceived to be a necessary auxiliary force in the event of war with India, which they continued to view as an existential threat. Further, if the Musharraf regime completely discontinued the use of proxies, then it would be much more difficult for it to resume support for militancy in the event a political payoff from India did not materialize. Pakistan therefore sought to reduce militant activities, while keeping strategic assets like Lashkar intact and thus maintaining the option of increasing pressure if necessary. Interlocutors in both countries have likened this approach to an old gas stove: Pakistan